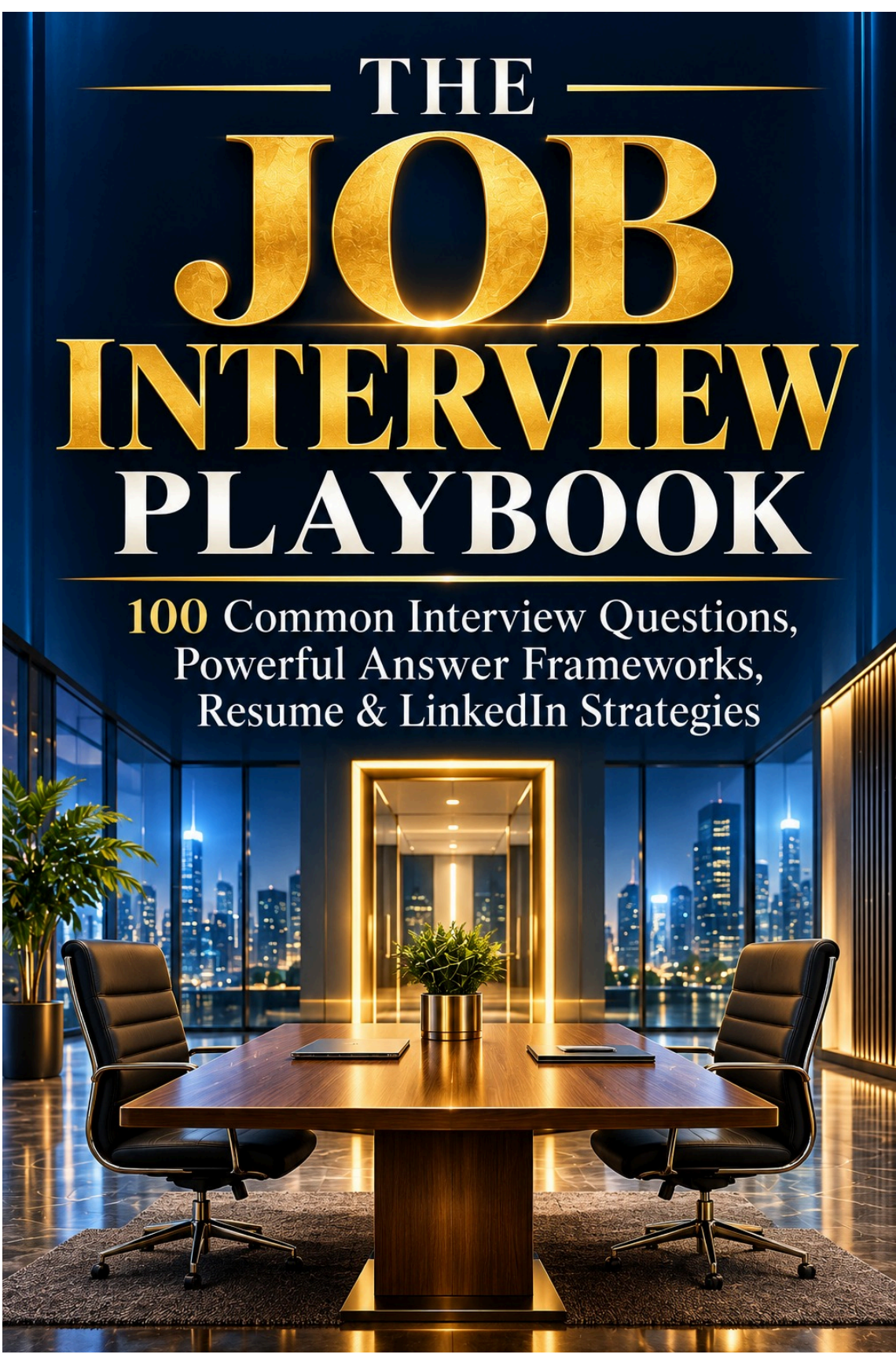
# THE JOB INTERVIEW PLAYBOOK

## 100 Common Interview Questions, Powerful Answer Frameworks, Resume & LinkedIn Strategies



THE JOB

# INTERVIEW PLAYBOOK

100 Common Interview Questions, Powerful Answer Frameworks, Resume & LinkedIn Strategies

Edition 1 · 2026

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## Educational notice

This book is general career guidance. It does not guarantee interviews, offers or any outcome. Hiring practices differ by employer and country. Example answers are fictional illustrations: use your own true experience.

## Sources

Statements of fact are supported by the references at the end of the book, with the date each source was checked. Web pages change; confirm current details before relying on them.

# Contents


Introduction 6

Chapter 1 Understanding the hiring process 8

Chapter 2 Resume writing 10

Chapter 3 Applicant tracking systems 13

Chapter 4 LinkedIn optimisation 15

Chapter 5 Cover letters 17

Chapter 6 Interview preparation 19

Chapter 7 Behavioural interviews 22

Chapter 8 Technical interviews 25

Chapter 9 Situational questions 27

Chapter 10 Communication skills 28

Chapter 11 Salary negotiation 30

Chapter 12 Interview follow-ups 33

Chapter 13 Job search planning 35

Chapter 14 Introductory and personal questions (Q1 to Q20) 37

Chapter 15 Behavioural questions (Q21 to Q40) 49

Chapter 16 Teamwork and leadership questions (Q41 to Q55) 60

Chapter 17 Problem-solving questions (Q56 to Q70) 69

**Chapter 18 Strengths, weaknesses and motivation (Q71 to Q80)** 77

**Chapter 19 Career and salary questions (Q81 to Q90)** 82

**Chapter 20 Challenging and unexpected questions (Q91 to Q100)** 87

**Appendix A. Story bank: 30 prompts** 92

**Appendix B. Common mistakes** 94

**Appendix C. Glossary** 95

**Conclusion** 96

**Appendix D. References and further reading** 97

# Introduction

This book has one purpose: to help you walk into an interview able to answer the questions you are most likely to be asked, truthfully and clearly. It also covers what happens before the interview (resume, applicant tracking systems, LinkedIn, cover letters) and after it (follow-ups, salary negotiation, planning your search).

It is written for university students, recent graduates and entry-level applicants, for experienced professionals moving up, and for career changers. Every one of the 100 questions in Chapters 14 to 20 has a separate **Beginner adaptation** and **Experienced candidate adaptation**, so you can use the same question whether you have six months of experience or sixteen years.

## The one rule: your answers must be true

Every example answer in this book is fictional and written to show structure. Do not copy them. Do not memorise them. An interviewer who asks a follow-up will find the gap between a borrowed story and your real memory within a minute, and an invented story is dishonest and can end an offer or a job later. Use each example to see the shape of a good answer, then build yours from things that really happened to you. Chapter 7 and the story bank in Appendix A show how to find those stories, including when you have little paid experience.

## What this book does not do

- It does not promise a job, an interview or a salary. Hiring depends on many things you do not control.
- It does not claim that any resume layout beats any applicant tracking system. Chapter 3 explains what is publicly known.
- It gives no field-specific facts about industries. Chapter 8 gives a method for preparing technical questions in any field.
- Country rules on pay disclosure, résumé conventions and employment law differ. Check local official sources.

## How to use it

1. Read Chapters 1 to 13 once, in order, to build your documents and your method.
2. Use Chapters 14 to 20 as a question bank. Read the question, cover the example, write your own answer from a real story, then compare.
3. Use the templates, checklists and the 30 day planner in the appendices.

## How this book was researched

Research was done on 2026-11-07. I read the official LinkedIn Help page on profiles, one employer FAQ and one university career service FAQ on applicant tracking, the US Office of Personnel Management page on structured interviews, and the US Bureau of Labor Statistics Occupational Outlook Handbook. I also reviewed competitor listings and could read only titles for most of them; see Appendix D. Where a statement rests on a source it is marked. Everything else is practical method, not statistics.

CHAPTER 1

# Understanding the hiring process

A hiring process is a series of filters, each answering a different question for the employer. Knowing the stage you are in tells you what to prepare.

## The usual stages

| Stage | Employer's question | What you do |
|---|---|---|
| Job posting | Who do we need? | Read it as a checklist |
| Application | Does this person match? | Tailored resume, short letter |
| Screening | Are they real, reachable, interested? | Short call or form |
| Interviews | Can they do it and fit here? | Prepared stories |
| Assessment | Can they show it? | Test, task, presentation |
| References and offer | Is it safe to hire? | Briefed referees, negotiation |

Not every employer uses every stage. Small firms may do one conversation; large ones may use five steps over weeks.

## Who is on the other side

A recruiter screens for basic fit and logistics. A hiring manager decides who can do the work. Team members judge whether they can work with you. Human resources handles process and the offer. Each reads your answers differently: the recruiter listens for a match to the posting, the manager for results, peers for how you treat people.

## Structured interviews

Many employers ask every candidate the same questions and score answers against the same standard. The US Office of Personnel Management describes structured interviews as measuring job related competencies by asking about past behaviour, about behaviour in hypothetical situations, or both, with the same questions and rating scale for all candidates (opm.gov, accessed 2026-11-07). This is why the book separates behavioural questions (Chapter 7) from situational ones (Chapter 9).

## Reading a job posting

Copy the posting into a document. Mark three groups: requirements you meet clearly, requirements you partly meet, and gaps. Underline repeated words; repetition shows priority. Your resume, letter and stories should cover the first two groups, and you should have an honest line for the third (see Q96 on gaps).

## What interviewers decide

Interviewers generally weigh three things: can you do the job, will you do it, and can they work with you. Every answer you give should support at least one.

CHAPTER 2

# Resume writing

A resume is a short, scannable document that proves you can do the work described in one particular posting.

## Principles

- One to two pages. One page is normal for students and early career; two for long careers.
- Reverse chronological order for most people, because it is the easiest for both people and software to read.
- Each bullet: action verb, what you did, result or scale. Use real numbers only if you know them; otherwise describe the outcome plainly.
- Tailor the top third (summary, skills, first bullets) to each posting by using its words where they honestly describe you.
- Do not lie, inflate titles or hide gaps with tricks. Ohio State Engineering Career Services warns against false information and hidden keywords (ecs.osu.edu, accessed 2026-11-07).

## Bullet formula

```
Action verb + task + method or tool + result/scale
Organised weekly stock counts using a shared spreadsheet,
cutting missing-item reports in my store section.
```

If you do not know the number, do not invent one. "Reduced" needs something real behind it.

# Plain text ATS safe structure

```
FULL NAME
City, Country | phone | email | LinkedIn URL

SUMMARY (2 lines, optional for students)
SKILLS (grouped, comma separated)
EXPERIENCE
  Job title, Employer, City, Month Year - Month Year
  - bullet
  - bullet
EDUCATION
  Degree, Institution, Year
PROJECTS / CERTIFICATIONS (if relevant)
```

## Example 1: beginner (fictional)

```
PRIYA NAIR
Pune, India | +91 00000 00000 | priya.nair@example.com

SUMMARY
Final-year commerce student with retail and tutoring experience,
seeking a junior accounts role.

SKILLS
Excel (pivot tables, lookups), Tally basics, written reports,
customer service

EXPERIENCE
Sales Assistant, Corner Books, Pune, Jun 2024 - Present
- Reconcile daily cash and card totals for a three-person shift
- Built a stock sheet in Excel that the owner now uses weekly
Peer Tutor, Commerce Department, Jan 2024 - Apr 2024
- Taught accounting basics to 8 first-year students weekly

EDUCATION
B.Com, Example University, expected 2026
```

## Example 2: experienced (fictional)

```
DANIEL OKAFOR
Manchester, UK | 00000 000000 | daniel.okafor@example.com
```

```
SUMMARY
Operations manager with 11 years in logistics. Run depots of
40-60 staff; focus on on-time delivery and safe working.

SKILLS
Route planning, workforce scheduling, SAP, supplier contracts

EXPERIENCE
Depot Manager, Northline Freight, Manchester, 2019 - Present
- Lead 52 staff across two shifts; own the weekly delivery plan
- Introduced a pre-shift safety briefing; incident reports fell
  from 14 to 9 in the year after (company records)
Shift Supervisor, Northline Freight, 2015 - 2019
- Scheduled drivers and loaders against daily order volumes

EDUCATION
BSc Business Management, Example University, 2013
```

## Career changers

Lead with a skills section mapped to the target role, then experience. Rename nothing falsely; instead add a line such as "Transferable: stakeholder reporting, budget tracking" and put relevant projects or courses before unrelated jobs only if the layout remains chronological and clear.

## Resume checklist

- [ ] Contact details in the body, not only in a header
- [ ] Standard headings (Experience, Education, Skills)
- [ ] Dates consistent
- [ ] No tables, text boxes, photos or graphics
- [ ] Each bullet shows an action and an outcome
- [ ] Proofread aloud; ask someone else to read it

CHAPTER 3

# Applicant tracking systems

An applicant tracking system (ATS) is software employers use to collect applications, store candidate data and manage stages. It is a database and workflow tool, not a magic gate.

## What is publicly said

I found no vendor neutral test showing how each major system parses each layout, so this chapter states only what employer and university sources say.

- Roche's careers FAQ says parsing extracts and organises resume data to help fill application fields and suggest matches; recruiters review each applicant and the attached CV; candidates should check that the data landed in the right fields (accessed 2026-11-07).
- The same FAQ advises against tables, text boxes, images, columns, headers and footers, and unusual section headings; it recommends standard fonts, contact details at the top and reverse chronological order, and says .docx parses most accurately.
- Ohio State Engineering Career Services says some systems parse the text of uploaded resumes, which can change formatting, and recommends PDF so recruiters see the intended layout; it also says recruiters, not the software, do most filtering, and that strong content matters more than gimmicks (accessed 2026-11-07).

These two sources disagree on file type. The safe rule is simple: follow the file type the posting asks for. If none is stated, ask or use the one the application form accepts.

## Practical consequences

1. Use a simple one column layout and standard headings.
2. Use the posting's wording where it truthfully describes you (job title, tools, qualifications).
3. After uploading, check the auto filled fields and fix errors.
4. Keep a plain version for applications and, if you want, a designed version to send to people directly.
5. Do not hide keywords in white text. Humans see it eventually and it reads as dishonest.

## What no one can promise

No layout, keyword count or score tool guarantees that a resume passes. How a given employer configures filtering varies and is not visible to you. Spend your effort on a truthful, relevant resume and on applying to roles you actually fit.

CHAPTER 4

# LinkedIn optimisation

This chapter states only what LinkedIn's official help page "Create a good LinkedIn profile" says (accessed 2026-11-07). Anything else here is general advice and is labelled as such.

## What LinkedIn says

- **Photo:** a professional photo adds credibility; members with a photo get up to 2X more profile views. You can add a background image.
- **Headline:** it can be rewritten to highlight an area of expertise or show personality.
- **About:** describe your mission, motivation and skills in one or two paragraphs; bullet points are acceptable.
- **Work and education:** keep them current and aligned with your goals; add media samples to show your work.
- **Skills:** list relevant skills; connections can endorse them and you can take assessments.
- **Recommendations:** request them from connections; there is no limit and you can hide ones that do not fit.
- **Profile strength meter:** a gauge of your profile's strength.

## General advice (not from LinkedIn)

Make the profile agree with your resume on titles and dates. Use the headline for what you do and want, not only your current title. Write the About in first person with one concrete example of your work.

## LinkedIn profile checklist

- [ ] Clear recent photo
- [ ] Headline states role and focus
- [ ] About in one or two paragraphs
- [ ] Experience and education current and consistent with resume
- [ ] Relevant skills listed
- [ ] At least one recommendation requested
- [ ] Contact details visible as you prefer
- [ ] Profile strength reviewed

## Headline examples (fictional)

```
Final-year economics student | Data analysis and research
Registered nurse | Paediatric ward | Patient education
Marketing coordinator moving into product management
```

CHAPTER 5

# Cover letters

A cover letter answers two questions the resume cannot: why this role, and why you. Keep it under one page, around 200 to 300 words.

## Structure

1. Opening: the role and one sentence on why it fits you.
2. Evidence: one or two real achievements matched to the posting.
3. Interest: something specific about the employer you actually learned.
4. Close: availability and thanks.

## Template

```
Dear [Name / Hiring Team],

I am applying for the [role] position. [One sentence connecting
your most relevant strength to their main need.]

In [role/project], I [action and result]. This matches your
need for [requirement from the posting].

I am drawn to [specific true detail about the organisation]
because [your reason].

I would welcome a conversation. I am available from [date].

Yours sincerely,
[Name]
```

## Example (fictional)

```
Dear Ms Ito,

I am applying for the Junior Content Editor role. I edit and
publish a student newsletter read by about 400 people, which is
close to the weekly cycle you describe.

Last term I introduced a simple checklist for fact-checking and
corrections dropped to nearly none, as the faculty adviser noted.

I admire your team's practice of publishing corrections openly,
and I would like to work in that culture.

I am available from 1 June.

Yours sincerely,
Kenji Mori
```

## Common mistakes

Repeating the resume line by line, using "To whom it may concern" when a name is findable, writing about what you want rather than what you offer, and sending the same letter to every employer.

CHAPTER 6

# Interview preparation

Preparation is mostly four jobs: know the employer, know your stories, sort the logistics, and practise aloud.

## Research the employer

Spend 45 minutes, not three days. Read the posting again, the employer's own website, recent news, and the profiles of your interviewers if you know them. Write down: what they sell or do, who they serve, one recent development, and one question it raises.

## Build your stories bank

Your answers will be drawn from 6 to 8 real stories covering work, study, volunteering or projects. Chapter 7 shows how; Appendix A has 30 prompts to find them. Map each story to the posting's top requirements.

## Logistics

- Confirm time zone, address or link, and interviewer names.
- Travel route and a spare 20 minutes, or test the link in advance.
- Bring copies of your resume, a notebook and your questions.
- Dress one level above the daily norm of that workplace if you can find out what it is.

## Remote and video interviews

- Test camera, microphone and internet the day before.
- Put the camera at eye height and light your face from the front.
- Close other applications and silence notifications.
- Look at the camera when you make key points.
- Have notes beside the screen, not on it. Keep a phone number for the interviewer in case of a connection failure.
- Pause slightly before answering; delay can make people talk over each other.

## Panel interviews

Write down names and roles as people introduce themselves. Answer mainly to the person who asked, but include eye contact with others. If one panellist is silent, still address the whole group at the end of each answer.

## Practice

Say your answers aloud, record yourself, and listen for filler, length and clarity. Practise with a friend who will interrupt with follow-ups, because real interviews contain them.

## Interview preparation checklist

- [ ] Posting marked into strong, partial and gap requirements
- [ ] Employer researched, one question prepared
- [ ] 6 to 8 stories written in short note form
- [ ] "Tell me about yourself" practised aloud
- [ ] Questions for the interviewer prepared (at least four)
- [ ] Logistics confirmed, route or link tested
- [ ] Documents and notes ready
- [ ] Sleep and meal planned

## Questions to ask the interviewer

```
What would success look like in the first six months?
What are the biggest challenges the team faces now?
How is feedback given and how often?
What are the next steps and timing?
```

Avoid asking things the website answers or opening with pay and leave.

CHAPTER 7

# Behavioural interviews

A behavioural question asks about something you did: "Tell me about a time when...". The reasoning is that past behaviour in similar situations gives evidence of how you work. The OPM page describes this as asking about past behaviour (opm.gov, accessed 2026-11-07).

## STAR

| Letter | Meaning | Share of answer |
|---|---|---|
| S | Situation: context in one or two sentences | 15% |
| T | Task: what you were responsible for | 10% |
| A | Action: what you personally did | 50% |
| R | Result: outcome and what you learned | 25% |

Those shares are a rule of thumb, not research. The key point is that Action is the core, and "I" must appear more than "we".

## Variants

- **CAR:** Challenge, Action, Result. Shorter, good for brief answers.
- **STAR+L:** add Learning at the end, useful for failure questions.
- **PREP (point, reason, example, point):** useful for opinion questions such as "Why this career?".
- **Past, present, future:** for "Tell me about yourself".

## Building a story bank

1. Use the 30 prompts in Appendix A. Write one or two lines per prompt. Many will be empty; that is normal.
2. Choose the six to eight richest. Include at least one failure, one conflict, one leadership moment, one improvement you made.
3. For each, write the true facts: dates, your role, numbers you actually know.
4. Tag each with the themes it can serve (teamwork, pressure, initiative).
5. Practise telling it in 90 seconds.

A single story can answer several questions. Reusing a good story is fine; reciting a memorised script is not. Know the facts, not the sentences.

## STAR worksheet

```
Story title:
Situation (where, when, who):
Task (my responsibility):
Action (3 specific things I did, in order):
Result (what changed; number if known):
What I learned:
Themes it can answer:
```

### Filled example (fictional)

```
Title: Late supplier at the bakery
Situation: Weekend rush, flour delivery missed, I was the
  duty supervisor.
Task: Keep the counter stocked for 200+ customers.
Action: Phoned two nearby shops for a loan, rebaked the best
  sellers first, told staff which items to prioritise.
Result: Sold out of only one line; owner changed supplier.
Learned: Keep a list of backup contacts.
Themes: pressure, initiative, problem-solving
```

## If you have no paid experience

Use study projects, volunteering, societies, family responsibilities, sports teams, part-time jobs. Interviewers know entry-level candidates draw from these.

CHAPTER 8

# Technical interviews

"Technical" means any question testing job-specific knowledge or skill. This book does not supply field facts; it gives a method you can use in any field.

## The preparation method

1. **Extract the skills.** From the posting, list the tools, methods and knowledge areas named.
2. **Rank them.** Mark those named most often and those you are weakest at.
3. **Find official or standard sources.** Use the course materials, professional body, tool documentation or a respected textbook for your field.
4. **Practise recall and application.** Explain each concept aloud in plain language, then solve two or three problems or cases without notes.
5. **Prepare one project.** Be able to explain one piece of real work end to end: goal, approach, mistakes, result.
6. **Practise thinking aloud.** Interviewers often assess process more than the final answer.

## Answering structure

Clarify the question, state assumptions, outline your approach, work through it, check the result, state limits. If you do not know, say what you do know, how you would find out, and where you would start.

## Examples of the same method in different fields (illustrative)

| Field | Typical task type | Your preparation |
|---|---|---|
| Software | Write or explain code | Practise problems; explain trade-offs aloud |
| Finance | Explain or build an analysis | Rebuild a simple model; explain assumptions |
| Marketing | Plan or critique a campaign | Prepare one campaign analysis with goals and measures |
| Operations | Improve a process | Map a process you know; show where delay occurs |

The exact content depends on the role. Do not rely on a list from a book for your field; use the employer's posting and your field's own resources.

## Case and take-home tasks

Ask about time limits and what is assessed. State assumptions in writing. Submit on time and a bit less ambitious rather than late.

## Common mistakes

Bluffing, going silent for a long time, skipping assumptions, memorising solutions without understanding, and failing to explain why.

CHAPTER 9

# Situational questions

A situational question describes a hypothetical: "What would you do if...". The OPM page lists hypothetical situations alongside past behaviour as structured interview methods (accessed 2026-11-07).

## Method

1. Restate the situation to confirm it.
2. Ask one or two clarifying questions, or state your assumptions.
3. Give your first step, then the reasoning.
4. Name the people involved and how you would communicate.
5. State what you would check afterwards.
6. Where possible, link to a real similar moment: "I faced something like this when...".

Situational answers should show judgement, ethics and willingness to ask for help. "It depends" is a valid start if you then say what it depends on.

## Pattern for a typical answer

```
First I would [confirm facts / safety]. Then I would
[action], because [reason]. I would involve [person] and
tell them [what]. Afterwards I would [follow-up]. If X
turned out to be true, I would instead [alternative].
```

Chapters 16, 17 and 20 contain many situational questions.

CHAPTER 10

# Communication skills

## Structure

Lead with the answer, then give one reason or story, then stop. If you can say it in 60 to 120 seconds, say it.

## Concision

Cut introductions ("That's a good question"), repeated qualifiers and detailed backstory. End with a clear closing sentence so the interviewer knows you are finished.

## Nerves

- Nerves are expected; interviewers often prefer a nervous but honest candidate over a polished evasive one.
- Slow your pace: breathe out slowly before you speak.
- Prepare the first 30 seconds of "Tell me about yourself" so you start steadily.
- Drink water; a pause to sip is acceptable.

## Listening

Note keywords in the question. If it has two parts, answer both. Watch for follow-up cues: a raised eyebrow or a pause often means the interviewer wants more detail.

## When your mind goes blank

Say: "Let me take a moment to think." Pause for five seconds. If nothing comes, offer a related story, or say "Could we come back to this question?" and return at the end.

## Asking for clarification

```
Could you tell me more about what you mean by [term]?
Do you mean in my last role, or in general?
Would you like a recent example or the most challenging one?
```

Clarifying shows care. Do it once or twice per interview, not every answer.

## Body language and voice

Sit upright, keep hands visible and relaxed, speak at a steady pace. Smile naturally when appropriate. On video, nod briefly to show you are listening.

CHAPTER 11

# Salary negotiation

Negotiation is a conversation about a fair match between your value and the employer's budget. No script guarantees a better offer; employers may have fixed bands.

## Research

- Official statistics: in the US the Bureau of Labor Statistics Occupational Outlook Handbook lists pay for many occupations and its website links to detailed wage data by occupation (bls.gov/ooh, accessed 2026-11-07). Other countries have their own statistical agencies.
- Posted ranges, where employers publish them.
- Professional bodies and unions.
- Conversations with people in similar roles (ask about ranges, not exact salaries).
- Salary sites: treat as rough, since data quality varies.

## Build your range

```
Floor: lowest number I would accept
Target: realistic number from research
Stretch: upper end if I can justify it
Non-pay items: leave, hours, remote days, training,
  start date, review date, bonus, relocation
```

## Timing

Avoid discussing pay until you understand the role, ideally until the employer is ready to offer. If asked early, give a researched range and say you are flexible depending on the whole package. Negotiate after the written or verbal offer, not before. Thank them first.

## Country differences

Practices differ: in some countries employers publish pay ranges, in others asking about previous salary is restricted or normal, and in some regions negotiating is expected while in others the offer is fixed by a grade scale. Rules differ by country and sometimes by region. Check your government's labour website or a local professional body before you rely on a rule.

## Scripts

### 1. Responding to an early salary question

> I would like to learn more about the role first. Based on my research for similar roles in [city], I am looking at [range], and I am open to discussing the full package.

### 2. Asking for more after an offer

> Thank you, I am excited about the role. Based on [research and my experience in X], I was hoping for [figure]. Is there flexibility?

### 3. Offer is fixed

> I understand the salary band is fixed. Could we look at [start date / training budget / review at six months]?

### 4. Comparing with another offer (only if true)

```
I have another offer at [range], but your role is my first
choice. Is there anything you can do on salary?
```

### 5. Asking for time

```
Thank you for the offer. May I have until [date] to review
it and respond?
```

### 6. Accepting

```
I am pleased to accept at [salary] with the terms we
discussed. Please send the written offer.
```

### 7. Declining politely

```
Thank you for the offer and your time. I have decided to
decline because [brief reason]. I hope we can stay in touch.
```

If they say no, decide beforehand whether you will accept anyway. Never state a competing offer that does not exist.

CHAPTER 12

# Interview follow-ups

Send a thank-you within 24 hours. It should be short, specific and accurate.

## Thank-you email templates

### 1. After a first interview

```
Subject: Thank you, [Role] interview

Dear [Name],
Thank you for speaking with me today about the [role].
I especially enjoyed hearing about [specific topic]. It
reinforced my interest, and I believe my experience in
[relevant skill] could help with [need discussed].
Please let me know if I can provide anything further.
Kind regards,
[Name]
```

### 2. After a panel

```
Dear [Names],
Thank you for the time you spent with me. [Name 1], your
point on [topic] was useful, and [Name 2], thank you for
explaining [topic]. I would be glad to contribute to...
```

### 3. After a final interview, adding a clarification

```
Dear [Name],
Thank you for today. One point I would like to add: in
```

```
answer to your question about [topic], [short addition].
I look forward to the next step.
```

### 4. When you want to keep the door open after a rejection

```
Dear [Name],
Thank you for letting me know. I appreciated the chance to
meet the team. If other roles arise, I would welcome the
chance to apply. Would you mind sharing any feedback?
```

## Follow-up scripts

1. **No reply after the stated date:** "I am following up on the [role]. I am still very interested and can provide any further information."
2. **Waiting after a week with no timeline:** "Could you let me know if the timeline for the decision has changed?"
3. **After a rejection, asking for feedback:** "I would appreciate any feedback that could help me improve."
4. **After accepting another offer, withdrawing:** "Thank you for your time. I have accepted another position and would like to withdraw my application."
5. **Contacting a referee in advance:** "I have given your name as a reference for [role]. Here is the posting and my resume."

Follow up at most twice, with a week between, unless told otherwise.

CHAPTER 13

# Job search planning

A search is easier when treated as a weekly routine. Track every application so you can follow up and learn.

## Application tracker

| Company | Role | Date | Stage | Next step |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Example Ltd | Analyst | 3 Mar | Interview 1 | Thank-you sent; follow up 12 Mar |

Add columns in a spreadsheet for: link, contact name, resume version, source, salary range, notes. Use a filter by stage, a date format column and conditional formatting for overdue follow-ups. Keep one row per application and update it the same day.

## 30 day job search planner

### Week 1: Foundations

- Define target roles (two or three) and locations.
- Write the master resume and story bank (Appendix A).
- Update LinkedIn using Chapter 4.
- Set up the tracker.

### Week 2: Applications

- Tailor and submit 5 to 8 applications to roles you fit.
- Write a base cover letter and adapt it.
- Message 3 people for short conversations.

- Practise "Tell me about yourself".

**Week 3: Practice**

- Practise 20 questions from Chapters 14 to 20 aloud.
- Do one mock interview with a friend or career service.
- Continue applications; follow up on week 2.
- Research salary range for targets.

**Week 4: Review**

- Check the tracker: what stage are applications at?
- Adjust resume based on responses.
- Prepare for any interviews with the checklist in Chapter 6.
- Plan the next 30 days.

Numbers here are suggestions, not targets proven to work; scale to your time. Rest and sleep belong in the plan.

## Networking

Ask for information, not jobs. Example message: "I am a final year student interested in [field]. Could I ask you two questions about your path?" Thank everyone you speak with.

CHAPTER 14

# Introductory and personal questions (Q1 to Q20)

These questions open most interviews. Every example answer below is a fictional illustration: use it to see the shape, then build your own from true experience. Do not memorise or copy it.

## Q1. Tell me about yourself.

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Whether you can summarise your relevant background clearly and start the conversation well.

**Answer framework:** Past, present, future: one relevant past step, current focus, why this role. Under 90 seconds.

**Example answer:** "I studied environmental science and spent last summer at a river-monitoring charity, where I entered water-sample data and spotted a recording error in one site's readings. Now I am finishing my dissertation on urban run-off. I am applying here because I want to turn that analytical work into practical policy, and your team's local projects fit that."

**Common mistakes:** Reciting your life story, repeating the resume, or listing hobbies only.

**Beginner adaptation:** Lead with study, projects and one volunteer or part-time experience tied to the job.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Start with your current scope, one major result, and why the next step is this role.

### Q2. Walk me through your resume.

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Whether your career story is coherent and whether you can explain choices.

**Answer framework:** Chronological headlines, one sentence per role: what you did, what you learned, why you moved.

**Example answer:** "I started as a pharmacy assistant, learning stock control and customer care. I moved to a clinic receptionist role to work with patients directly, then into appointment coordination, where I redesigned the weekly schedule. Each move added responsibility. This role combines scheduling and patient contact, which are the parts I enjoy most."

**Common mistakes:** Reading dates aloud, spending too long on the oldest roles.

**Beginner adaptation:** Walk through education first, then projects and jobs, linking each to the role.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Compress early roles to one sentence; spend most time on the last two.

### Q3. Why did you apply for this role?

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Whether your interest is specific and genuine.

**Answer framework:** Two reasons from the posting, one skill you bring, one honest personal reason.

**Example answer:** "Your posting stresses forecasting for small retailers, which I did in my statistics project using a local shop's sales. I like work where numbers lead to a decision a real owner can act on. The role

also lets me use Python, which I want to deepen. Those three things made this the first application I wrote."

**Common mistakes:** Generic praise, mentioning only salary or location.

**Beginner adaptation:** Link a course, project or placement directly to a posting requirement.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Name the problem the role solves and your past evidence of solving similar ones.

### Q4. Why do you want to work for our company?

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Whether you researched them and are likely to stay.

**Answer framework:** One fact you learned, why it matters to you, how you would contribute.

**Example answer:** "I read your annual report and noticed you opened two community kitchens last year. I volunteered at a food bank for two years and saw how much a stable local kitchen matters. I would like to work for an organisation that measures impact by meals served, and my events experience could help with fundraising."

**Common mistakes:** Quoting the mission statement, flattering without evidence.

**Beginner adaptation:** Use a product you have used, an event you attended or a talk by their staff.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Connect a company strategy or challenge to a result you have delivered.

### Q5. What do you know about our organisation?

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Your preparation and curiosity.

**Answer framework:** Three facts (what they do, who they serve, recent development) and one question.

**Example answer:** "You design modular school furniture, sell mainly to local authorities, and recently launched a recycled-plastic range. I read that tender cycles are long, so I would like to ask how the team keeps relationships warm between tenders. I am particularly interested in the recycled line because of my product design coursework."

**Common mistakes:** Reciting the About page, or admitting you did not look.

**Beginner adaptation:** Use the website, a news item and one customer review you read.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Include a competitor comparison and a risk or opportunity you see.

### Q6. What are your career goals?

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Whether your direction fits what the role can offer.

**Answer framework:** Short-term skill goal, medium-term responsibility goal, and how this role is a step.

**Example answer:** "In the next two years I want to be solid at clinical documentation and ward routines. After that I would like to take on mentoring student nurses, because I enjoyed supervising a first-year on placement. A hospital with a structured preceptor programme like yours is a good fit for both."

**Common mistakes:** "I want your job", or having no goals.

**Beginner adaptation:** Name skills you want to master and the field you are building toward.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Name the scope you want next and show how this employer can provide it.

## Q7. Where do you see yourself in five years?

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Ambition, realism, and likelihood of staying.

**Answer framework:** Skills, scope, contribution. Avoid exact titles you cannot control.

**Example answer:** "I hope to have become the person the team trusts for complex customer cases, and perhaps to be training new joiners. I would like to understand the product deeply, not just the support scripts. If the company grows, I would be glad to take more responsibility."

**Common mistakes:** Saying you will start a business, or "I don't know" without a thought.

**Beginner adaptation:** Show willingness to learn and to take on more with time.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Show where you can create value and how your past leads to a larger remit.

## Q8. What motivates you?

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** What drives your effort and whether the role supplies it.

**Answer framework:** One true motivator, one example, link to the job.

**Example answer:** "Fixing things that waste people's time. At a call centre I noticed callers repeating account details three times, so I proposed a note field and a short checklist. Calls shortened by about a minute according to my supervisor's sample. Seeing a daily annoyance disappear motivates me more than targets."

**Common mistakes:** Saying only money, or a vague "challenge".

**Beginner adaptation:** Draw on study, volunteering or sport where you saw this motivation.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Cite a pattern across roles and one large example.

## Q9. Why did you choose your degree or field of study?

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Your decision-making and interest.

**Answer framework:** Origin of interest, what you learned, how it connects to the job.

**Example answer:** "I took a statistics elective expecting it to be dull and found I loved asking whether a result was real. That led me to choose a data-focused economics degree. The course taught me to question numbers, which is exactly what an audit role needs."

**Common mistakes:** Blaming parents or luck, or saying you regret it.

**Beginner adaptation:** Link a favourite module to the role's tasks.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Explain briefly, then show how your career has built on or moved from it.

## Q10. What do you do outside work or study?

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Personality, balance and transferable traits.

**Answer framework:** One or two true activities, a trait they show.

**Example answer:** "I coach an under-12 football team on Saturdays. It taught me to explain things simply to people who do not want to listen. I also cycle to work, which keeps me alert. Both help me stay patient in busy weeks."

**Common mistakes:** Listing many hobbies, or hiding that you have none.

**Beginner adaptation:** Societies, sport, creative projects, caring responsibilities.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Mention anything that shows long-term commitment, such as mentoring or board roles.

## Q11. How would your colleagues describe you?

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Self-awareness and reputation.

**Answer framework:** Two traits, each backed by something a colleague actually said or did.

**Example answer:** "Reliable and calm. My supervisor at the warehouse once said she gave me the late-shift handovers because nothing got dropped. A teammate also told me I explain procedures clearly. I try to deserve both."

**Common mistakes:** Claiming praise that you cannot support.

**Beginner adaptation:** Quote feedback from tutors, teammates or managers.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Use performance review language and one concrete comment.

## Q12. What are you looking for in your next role?

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Whether the role can satisfy you.

**Answer framework:** Three needs that match the job: skills, type of work, environment.

**Example answer:** "I want a role where I do hands-on design work and get feedback from senior designers. I also want to see my work used by real customers. Your studio ships small client projects every month, which suits both."

**Common mistakes:** Listing needs that the job obviously cannot meet.

**Beginner adaptation:** Emphasise learning, mentorship and breadth.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Emphasise scope, autonomy and impact.

## Q13. Why are you leaving your current job?

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Your attitude and reliability.

**Answer framework:** Positive pull toward this role; one neutral fact; no blame.

**Example answer:** "I have enjoyed four years in the bank, but the branch has no route into the commercial team, which is where I want to work. Your role offers client work with small firms. I am leaving on good terms and will work my full notice."

**Common mistakes:** Blaming a manager, or sharing salary frustration first.

**Beginner adaptation:** For a first move, say you want more responsibility or a better skills match.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Frame the change as a growth step or restructure, factually.

## Q14. What is your proudest achievement?

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** What you value and what you can do.

**Answer framework:** STAR, with a result and your personal part.

**Example answer:** "Finishing my first marathon after a knee injury. I built a twelve-week plan with a physiotherapist, kept a log, and adjusted when pain returned. I finished in five hours, slowly but without injury. It taught me patience and structured planning, which I use in project work."

**Common mistakes:** Boasting about team results as yours alone.

**Beginner adaptation:** A project, competition or personal goal is fine.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Pick one with measurable business impact and your specific role.

## Q15. How do you keep up to date in your field?

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Curiosity and self-development.

**Answer framework:** Two concrete habits and a recent example of something learned.

**Example answer:** "I follow two industry newsletters and join a monthly local meetup. Last month I learned about a new reporting standard there and checked how it affects our template. I keep short notes and share a summary with my team."

**Common mistakes:** Saying "I read the news" without specifics.

**Beginner adaptation:** Courses, professional student bodies, free resources.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Speaking, teaching, certifications and how you apply learning.

## Q16. What does a good workday look like for you?

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Working style and fit.

**Answer framework:** Describe rhythm, collaboration, outcomes.

**Example answer:** "A focused morning on the hardest task, a short check-in with teammates, and an afternoon of meetings and replies. I finish having moved one important thing forward and left clear notes for tomorrow."

**Common mistakes:** Describing a day with no work or no people.

**Beginner adaptation:** Base it on study or placement days.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Include how you balance delegation and hands-on work.

## Q17. Describe your ideal manager.

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Your needs and whether you can work with their style.

**Answer framework:** Two qualities, an example of a good past manager, flexibility.

**Example answer:** "Someone who is clear about priorities and gives regular feedback. My team lead in the café did a five-minute review every Friday, and I improved quickly. I adapt to different styles, but clear expectations help me most."

**Common mistakes:** Criticising past managers.

**Beginner adaptation:** Mention tutors, coaches or supervisors you learned from.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Mention how you work with managers who are hands-off or detailed.

## Q18. Why should we hire you?

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Your fit against their needs.

**Answer framework:** Their need, your matching evidence, your difference.

**Example answer:** "You need someone who can run supplier orders from day one. I have run weekly orders for a restaurant for two years without stockouts on core items, and I know the software you use. I also learn quickly, as I did when I took over the allergen records."

**Common mistakes:** Comparing yourself to other candidates.

**Beginner adaptation:** Combine skills, learning speed and motivation, with proof.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Lead with a result directly relevant to the role's biggest need.

## Q19. How did you hear about this role?

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Your search habits and genuine interest.

**Answer framework:** The honest source and what drew you.

**Example answer:** "A former colleague, Maria, who works in your logistics team, told me the planner role had opened. I read the description that night and saw it matches the scheduling work I do now."

**Common mistakes:** Lying about a referral, or saying you applied to everything.

**Beginner adaptation:** Career fair, university board, society event.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Recruiter, network, or following the company.

## Q20. Do you have any questions for us?

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Engagement and judgement.

**Answer framework:** Three prepared questions on success, team and next steps.

**Example answer:** "Yes. What would you expect me to have achieved by the end of six months? How does the team handle disagreements about priorities? And what are the next steps in the process?"

**Common mistakes:** Saying "No", or asking only about pay and holiday.

**Beginner adaptation:** Ask about training, mentoring and typical first projects.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Ask about strategy, team gaps and measures of success.

CHAPTER 15

# Behavioural questions (Q21 to Q40)

Each answer here should use a real STAR story from your own bank (Chapter 7).

## Q21. Tell me about a time you failed.

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Honesty, accountability and learning.

**Answer framework:** STAR plus Learning; own the cause; show what changed.

**Example answer:** "I missed a grant deadline because I assumed our partner would send the budget. I never confirmed. We submitted a day late and lost the round. I apologised to my director, wrote a checklist with a two-day confirmation step, and have used it on every application since. We have not missed a deadline in the three submissions after."

**Common mistakes:** Choosing a fake failure, or blaming others.

**Beginner adaptation:** A study, sport or part-time work failure is fine.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Pick a real professional miss with consequences and a lasting process change.

## Q22. Tell me about a time you met a tight deadline.

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Planning, prioritisation, and composure.

**Answer framework:** The constraint, your plan, your choices, the result.

**Example answer:** "Two days before a client launch, our translator fell ill. I listed what was essential, asked a bilingual colleague to check the key pages, and moved the remaining pages to a second release. The launch went ahead on time with the essential content, and the rest followed three days later."

**Common mistakes:** Saying you worked all night without explaining choices.

**Beginner adaptation:** Use an assignment or placement deadline.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Show triage and stakeholder communication.

## Q23. Tell me about a time you handled criticism.

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Openness to feedback.

**Answer framework:** What was said, your first reaction honestly, what you changed, result.

**Example answer:** "My tutor said my lab reports were accurate but hard to follow. I was annoyed at first, then asked for an example of a clear report. I changed my structure to put the result first. My next mark rose a grade, and I still use that layout."

**Common mistakes:** Claiming you never received criticism.

**Beginner adaptation:** Use tutor or coach feedback.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Use feedback from a senior or a review, and show durable change.

## Q24. Tell me about a time you went above and beyond.

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Initiative and ownership.

**Answer framework:** The need no one assigned, what you did, impact.

**Example answer:** "Our shop's returns were handled on paper, and customers waited. In my own time I built a one-page form and trained the evening staff. Return time dropped from about ten minutes to five on the days I timed. My manager adopted the form in the other branches."

**Common mistakes:** Describing normal duties as extra.

**Beginner adaptation:** A volunteer, society or classroom initiative.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Show scale and sustained effect.

## Q25. Tell me about a mistake you made and how you fixed it.

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Integrity and problem handling.

**Answer framework:** What happened, how you told people, fix, prevention.

**Example answer:** "I sent a payroll file with an incorrect rate for two staff. I noticed it an hour later, told my manager at once, and corrected the payments before they were issued. I then added a second-person check on rate changes, and none have been wrong since."

**Common mistakes:** Hiding the mistake, or minimising it.

**Beginner adaptation:** Use a small error with a clear fix.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Show disclosure to stakeholders and system change.

## Q26. Tell me about a time you had to learn something quickly.

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Learning agility.

**Answer framework:** The need, your learning method, speed, outcome.

**Example answer:** "Our team changed to a new project tool on a Monday, and I was the only one with a free week. I used the vendor's tutorials, wrote a one-page guide and ran a thirty-minute session on Wednesday. By Friday the team had moved their tasks over."

**Common mistakes:** Not saying how you learned.

**Beginner adaptation:** Learning a software, language or lab method for a course.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Show you learned and also taught others.

## Q27. Tell me about a time you managed multiple priorities.

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Organisation and judgement.

**Answer framework:** List, rank by impact and deadline, communicate, deliver.

**Example answer:** "During exam month I also had two shifts and a society event. I listed everything by deadline and importance, told the society I could only organise logistics, and asked my manager to shift one shift. I passed every exam and the event ran."

**Common mistakes:** Saying you "just multitask".

**Beginner adaptation:** Combine study with work or activities.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Show you said no, delegated or renegotiated.

## Q28. Tell me about a time you showed initiative.

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Whether you act without being told.

**Answer framework:** Spot the opportunity, take a small step, show result.

**Example answer:** "I noticed our clinic's FAQ list was out of date and patients asked the same questions at reception. I asked the manager if I could update it, drafted it with a nurse, and printed copies. Reception reported fewer repeat questions in the following month."

**Common mistakes:** Choosing an initiative with no result.

**Beginner adaptation:** Volunteer or campus examples.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Examples that affected the team or budget.

## Q29. Tell me about a difficult customer or client.

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Composure and service.

**Answer framework:** Listen, acknowledge, solve, follow up.

**Example answer:** "A guest was angry that her room was not ready. I listened without interrupting, apologised, offered a seat in the lounge with a drink, and checked housekeeping. I updated her every ten minutes and gave her a late checkout. She thanked me when she left."

**Common mistakes:** Blaming the customer.

**Beginner adaptation:** Retail, hospitality, or help desk experience.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Show de-escalation and a systemic fix.

## Q30. Tell me about a time you adapted to change.

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Flexibility.

**Answer framework:** The change, your reaction, steps, outcome.

**Example answer:** "When our department merged with another, my reporting line changed and half my tasks moved. I met my new manager, wrote down what I would keep and what I would hand over, and offered to document the old process. The handover finished in three weeks."

**Common mistakes:** Complaining about the change.

**Beginner adaptation:** Changing course, group or placement.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Restructures, systems, leadership change.

## Q31. Tell me about a time you worked under pressure.

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Resilience.

**Answer framework:** Pressure source, how you kept quality, what you learned.

**Example answer:** "On a busy Friday our kitchen lost a cook mid-service. I took over the grill, asked the runner to call out orders in sequence, and kept a note of delays for the manager. We served everyone, though some waited fifteen minutes longer than usual."

**Common mistakes:** Claiming pressure never affects you.

**Beginner adaptation:** Exams, shifts, live events.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Crisis responsibilities and decisions.

## Q32. Tell me about a time you persuaded someone.

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Influence without authority.

**Answer framework:** Understand their concern, use evidence, compromise, outcome.

**Example answer:** "I wanted our lab to switch to a shared sample register. The senior technician worried about extra work. I tested it for a week on my own samples and showed it saved twenty minutes of searching. He agreed to a trial and later made it standard."

**Common mistakes:** Pushing, or winning by authority.

**Beginner adaptation:** Convincing a group or tutor.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Persuading executives with data and risk.

## Q33. Tell me about a time you disagreed with a decision.

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Professionalism in dissent.

**Answer framework:** State concern respectfully, offer evidence, accept outcome.

**Example answer:** "My supervisor decided to ship an order with a minor print fault to meet a date. I raised the concern in private, suggested a partial shipment, and accepted her decision. Later the client complained, and she asked me to lead the reprint. I learned to document my concern in writing."

**Common mistakes:** Bad-mouthing the decision-maker.

**Beginner adaptation:** Group project disagreements.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Cross-functional or leadership disagreement and what you did after.

## Q34. Tell me about a time you made a decision without full information.

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Judgement under uncertainty.

**Answer framework:** What you knew, assumptions, decision, check.

**Example answer:** "A supplier said a part might not arrive on time. We had no certainty, so I ordered a smaller emergency batch from a second source, which cost slightly more. The first part arrived late, and the emergency batch kept production running."

**Common mistakes:** Saying you always wait for full data.

**Beginner adaptation:** Choice of project topic, tools or approach.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Budget, hiring or vendor decisions.

## Q35. Tell me about a time you took a risk.

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Appetite for risk and how you manage it.

**Answer framework:** Risk, safeguards, decision, outcome.

**Example answer:** "I proposed running our society's annual talk online for the first time. The risk was lower attendance. I tested the platform with a small group, kept a room booked as a fallback, and promoted it widely. We had more attendees than the previous year."

**Common mistakes:** Describing recklessness.

**Beginner adaptation:** Trying a new approach on a project.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** A business risk with mitigation and results.

## Q36. Tell me about a time you improved a process.

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Continuous improvement.

**Answer framework:** Problem, analysis, change, measure.

**Example answer:** "Our pharmacy team repeated allergy checks at two stages. I mapped the steps, saw the duplication, and proposed one verified check at intake. After a month's trial, queue times dropped, and the pharmacist approved it."

**Common mistakes:** Not measuring the change.

**Beginner adaptation:** A study or club process.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Cost, time or quality metrics.

## Q37. Tell me about a time you faced an ethical dilemma.

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Integrity.

**Answer framework:** The conflict, the principle, what you did, outcome.

**Example answer:** "A manager asked me to adjust a delivery date in our records so a target looked met. I explained that the record needed to be accurate, offered to show the real cause of the delay, and escalated to compliance when he insisted. The record stayed accurate."

**Common mistakes:** Choosing a minor dilemma or a fake one.

**Beginner adaptation:** Academic honesty, placement confidentiality.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Policy, compliance and escalation.

### Q38. Tell me about a time you worked with limited resources.

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Resourcefulness.

**Answer framework:** Constraint, priorities, creative options, result.

**Example answer:** "Our school club had a budget of 50 pounds for an open day. I borrowed display boards from the art department, asked members to bring baked goods, and printed posters at the library. We reached about 80 visitors."

**Common mistakes:** Complaining about constraints.

**Beginner adaptation:** Student societies and projects.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Budget cuts or headcount limits.

### Q39. Tell me about a time you had to say no.

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Boundaries and judgement.

**Answer framework:** The request, your reason, alternative offered, relationship preserved.

**Example answer:** "A colleague asked me to cover his shift on the day of my exam. I explained why I could not, and offered to cover the following week. He found another cover, and we agreed a swap."

**Common mistakes:** Never saying no, or refusing rudely.

**Beginner adaptation:** Balancing study and work.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Protecting scope and quality with stakeholders.

### Q40. Tell me about a time you explained something complex to a non-expert.

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Communication clarity.

**Answer framework:** Know the audience, simplify with an analogy, check understanding.

**Example answer:** "I had to explain a billing error to an elderly customer. I drew a simple timeline of when charges applied, avoided jargon, and asked her to tell me back what she understood. She agreed with the correction and thanked me."

**Common mistakes:** Using jargon.

**Beginner adaptation:** Teaching a friend or presenting to a class.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Briefing executives or clients.

CHAPTER 16

# Teamwork and leadership questions (Q41 to Q55)

## Q41. How do you work with a difficult team member?

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Your ability to cooperate when it is hard.

**Answer framework:** Understand the cause, talk directly, focus on the task, escalate only if needed.

**Example answer:** "A teammate on a data project rarely replied to messages. I asked him privately what was blocking him. He was overloaded with another course. We agreed shorter tasks and fixed check-ins, and the report was finished on time."

**Common mistakes:** Complaining about the person.

**Beginner adaptation:** Use a group assignment.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Use a cross-team stakeholder and show escalation judgement.

## Q42. What role do you usually take in a team?

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Self-awareness and flexibility.

**Answer framework:** Usual role, evidence, how you flex.

**Example answer:** "I tend to be the organiser: I keep the task list and check deadlines. On a design project I noticed I was talking too much, so I stepped back and let a quieter member lead the presentation. It went better."

**Common mistakes:** Saying you are always the leader or always the follower.

**Beginner adaptation:** Sport, class or club teams.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Describe different roles in different team stages.

## Q43. Tell me about a conflict with a coworker.

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Maturity in disagreement.

**Answer framework:** Facts, conversation, shared goal, resolution.

**Example answer:** "A colleague and I disagreed over who should update the weekly report. I asked to talk, we listed tasks on a whiteboard, and agreed to alternate weeks. The report has been on time since."

**Common mistakes:** Making yourself the hero and the other person the villain.

**Beginner adaptation:** Flatmates, club or project conflicts that show process.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Interdepartmental conflict handled with data and a clear compromise.

## Q44. Tell me about a time you led a team or project.

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Leadership behaviour.

**Answer framework:** Goal, how you organised people, obstacles, result.

**Example answer:** "I led a team of five to organise a charity quiz night. I assigned tasks by strength, held a short weekly check-in, and handled the venue negotiation myself. We raised money for the local hospice and finished under budget."

**Common mistakes:** Using "we" so much your role is unclear.

**Beginner adaptation:** Society, project or sports captaincy.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Scale, budget, people, and your decisions.

## Q45. How do you motivate others?

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Leadership style.

**Answer framework:** Understand what each person values, give clear goals, recognise effort.

**Example answer:** "I ask what each person wants from the work. One volunteer wanted to learn social media, so I gave her the campaign. Another liked structure, so I gave her the schedule. Both stayed until the end."

**Common mistakes:** Saying "I lead by example" and stopping.

**Beginner adaptation:** Group leadership, tutoring.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Include feedback cycles, targets and development.

## Q46. How do you give feedback to a peer?

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Tact and directness.

**Answer framework:** Private, specific, behaviour not personality, ask for their view, agree next step.

**Example answer:** "A colleague's slides were hard to read. I asked if he wanted feedback, then said the font was small for a large room and suggested a layout. He changed it and thanked me."

**Common mistakes:** Avoiding feedback or being harsh.

**Beginner adaptation:** Peer review in coursework.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Include follow-up and a documented outcome.

### Q47. How do you work in a remote or distributed team?

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Communication discipline.

**Answer framework:** Clear written updates, agreed hours, tools, check-ins.

**Example answer:** "On a project with members in three time zones we agreed core overlap hours, posted daily written updates, and recorded decisions in a shared document. It prevented repeated questions and kept us on schedule."

**Common mistakes:** Saying remote is the same as in-person.

**Beginner adaptation:** Online coursework groups.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Team norms and handover practices.

## Q48. What do you do if a teammate causes you to miss a deadline?

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Accountability and problem-solving.

**Answer framework:** Raise early, fix what you can, communicate to the stakeholder, learn.

**Example answer:** "I would tell my teammate straight away what I need and by when. If it still slipped, I would inform our lead with a revised date and a plan, without blaming. Afterwards I would agree earlier check-ins."

**Common mistakes:** Blaming without solutions.

**Beginner adaptation:** Group project example.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Cross-team dependency management.

## Q49. How would you handle a team member who isn't pulling their weight?

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Fairness and courage.

**Answer framework:** Private conversation, find cause, clarify expectations, escalate if needed.

**Example answer:** "I would ask privately whether something was getting in the way, explain what I needed, and offer help. If it continued, I would raise it with the supervisor and share facts, not opinions."

**Common mistakes:** Going straight to the manager or ignoring it.

**Beginner adaptation:** Group coursework.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Include performance management and support.

## Q50. How do you delegate work?

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Trust and clarity.

**Answer framework:** Match task to person, define outcome, give resources, check in.

**Example answer:** "I explain the goal and the deadline, not every step. I ask what support they need and book a short check-in halfway. When I delegated the supplier calls to a junior colleague, he found a better price."

**Common mistakes:** Micromanaging, or delegating without support.

**Beginner adaptation:** Distributing tasks in a society.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Show trade-offs and developing people.

## Q51. How do you build relationships with stakeholders?

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Influence and communication.

**Answer framework:** Identify, understand needs, regular updates, reliability.

**Example answer:** "I list who is affected by the work and ask each what they need to know and how often. For the building project I sent a Friday summary to the residents, which reduced complaints."

**Common mistakes:** Only contacting stakeholders when there is a problem.

**Beginner adaptation:** Clubs, community or group clients.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Senior stakeholder mapping.

## Q52. How do you manage a team member who is underperforming?

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Management judgement.

**Answer framework:** Clear facts, listen, set expectations, support, review.

**Example answer:** "I would meet privately, show specific examples of the gap, and ask for their view. We would agree two or three targets and weekly reviews. If there is no improvement, I would follow the company process with HR."

**Common mistakes:** Avoiding the conversation, or being punitive.

**Beginner adaptation:** Describe how you'd approach it, with a peer-mentoring example.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Give a real case, process followed and the result.

## Q53. What is your leadership style?

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Self-awareness and fit.

**Answer framework:** Core approach, example, adaptation.

**Example answer:** "I lead by setting clear goals and then giving people room. With newer staff I check in more often, and with experienced ones I step back. When my team was short-staffed, I took the least popular shift myself."

**Common mistakes:** Buzzwords such as "servant leader" without evidence.

**Beginner adaptation:** Describe how you lead group projects.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Link style to team outcomes.

## Q54. How do you work with people very different from you?

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Respect and adaptability.

**Answer framework:** Curiosity, shared goals, communication, example.

**Example answer:** "On a summer job with staff of all ages, I asked each person how they preferred to receive instructions. One older colleague wanted written notes, a younger one a quick chat. Adjusting made the team smoother."

**Common mistakes:** Saying you treat everyone the same.

**Beginner adaptation:** Student groups, societies, exchange programmes.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** International or cross-functional teams.

## Q55. Tell me about a time you helped a struggling colleague.

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Empathy and teamwork.

**Answer framework:** Notice, offer help, support without taking over, outcome.

**Example answer:** "A new colleague was falling behind with order entry. I offered to sit with her for twenty minutes each morning and showed my shortcut. In two weeks she was at normal speed."

**Common mistakes:** Doing their work for them.

**Beginner adaptation:** Study group or volunteering.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Mentoring and development outcomes.

CHAPTER 17

# Problem-solving questions (Q56 to Q70)

## Q56. Describe a complex problem you solved.

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Analytical thinking.

**Answer framework:** Define, break down, test options, decide, check.

**Example answer:** "Our delivery vans were often late. I mapped routes and times for two weeks and found most delays came from one loading bay queue. I proposed staggered loading slots. Late deliveries fell the next month."

**Common mistakes:** Skipping how you analysed.

**Beginner adaptation:** Coursework or personal project.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Complex multi-factor problems with data.

## Q57. How do you approach analysing data?

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Method and rigour.

**Answer framework:** Question, clean data, explore, test, communicate.

**Example answer:** "I start with the question, check the data for gaps, look at simple summaries, then test one idea at a time. I always check my numbers against a known total before presenting."

**Common mistakes:** Naming tools only.

**Beginner adaptation:** Describe a course project.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Include business decisions and limits.

## Q58. How do you prioritise when everything is urgent?

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Judgement.

**Answer framework:** Clarify deadlines and impact, ask the manager, communicate trade-offs.

**Example answer:** "I list tasks by deadline and consequence, then ask my manager to confirm the order if two conflict. If a task must wait, I tell the person affected and give a new time."

**Common mistakes:** Saying you do everything at once.

**Beginner adaptation:** Exams and assignments.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Stakeholder trade-offs.

## Q59. Tell me about a time you noticed a problem others missed.

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Attention to detail and speaking up.

**Answer framework:** What you saw, how you checked, who you told, result.

**Example answer:** "While counting stock I saw that one product's quantity did not match deliveries. I checked invoices and found a supplier had shipped short for two months. We received a credit."

**Common mistakes:** Claiming credit for team discoveries.

**Beginner adaptation:** Lab or coursework example.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Financial or operational risk.

## Q60. Describe a creative solution you came up with.

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Creativity within constraints.

**Answer framework:** Problem, options, chosen idea, result.

**Example answer:** "Our library had few visitors on Fridays. I suggested a quiet study hour with free tea. A few weeks later, Friday visits had roughly doubled by the staff's count."

**Common mistakes:** Vague ideas without results.

**Beginner adaptation:** Club or study ideas.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Business improvements with cost.

## Q61. What do you do when you don't know the answer?

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Honesty and resourcefulness.

**Answer framework:** Say so, state what you know, find out, check.

**Example answer:** "I say I am not sure, share what I do know, and tell them how I will find the answer. At the helpdesk I would check the knowledge base, ask a senior colleague and then call the customer back."

**Common mistakes:** Bluffing.

**Beginner adaptation:** Use a learning moment from study.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Include whom you consult and how you document.

## Q62. How would you estimate how many coffee shops a city has?

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Structured reasoning, not the exact number.

**Answer framework:** State assumptions, break into parts, compute, sanity check.

**Example answer:** "I would assume the city has 500,000 people, and one shop for about 2,500 people near commercial areas. 500,000 divided by 2,500 is 200. Then I would adjust: city centres have more, so I might say between 200 and 300, and check against a business directory."

**Common mistakes:** Silence or giving a number without steps.

**Beginner adaptation:** Practise with simple arithmetic and say assumptions.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Use data sources you would check.

## Q63. What would you do in your first 90 days?

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Planning and realism.

**Answer framework:** Learn, build relationships, deliver a small win.

**Example answer:** "First month: learn the systems, meet the team and customers. Second: take on part of the workload and propose one improvement. Third: deliver a small project and review with my manager."

**Common mistakes:** Promising to change everything.

**Beginner adaptation:** Learning, support, small tasks.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Listen first, then change with data.

## Q64. How do you handle unclear instructions?

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Communication and initiative.

**Answer framework:** Clarify, restate, confirm in writing.

**Example answer:** "I ask what the goal is, who will use the output and when it's due. Then I send a short note: 'My understanding is...' If something changes, I update it."

**Common mistakes:** Guessing silently.

**Beginner adaptation:** Assignments with vague briefs.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Senior stakeholder requests.

## Q65. What process would you improve in this role?

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Insight and humility.

**Answer framework:** Observe first, hypothesise, ask how it works now.

**Example answer:** "I do not know your process yet, but from the posting I would ask how orders are tracked. If it is manual, I would test a shared spreadsheet before suggesting anything bigger."

**Common mistakes:** Criticising the employer without knowing.

**Beginner adaptation:** Offer a general approach, ask questions.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Use a comparable improvement you made.

## Q66. A project is falling behind schedule. What do you do?

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Project judgement.

**Answer framework:** Diagnose, options, communicate, re-plan.

**Example answer:** "I would find where the delay is, then list options: reduce scope, add help, or move the date. I would tell the sponsor early with a recommended option, and update the plan."

**Common mistakes:** Hiding delays.

**Beginner adaptation:** Group project example.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Cost and risk trade-offs.

## Q67. A customer complains about a product. What do you do?

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Service and process.

**Answer framework:** Listen, apologise, solve, record, follow up.

**Example answer:** "I would listen, apologise for the experience, check the details, offer a fix or refund within policy, and record the issue so the team can spot patterns. I would follow up in a week."

**Common mistakes:** Arguing or promising outside policy.

**Beginner adaptation:** Retail or hospitality experience.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Escalation and root cause.

## Q68. Two deadlines clash. What do you do?

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Prioritisation.

**Answer framework:** Impact, ask, negotiate, communicate.

**Example answer:** "I would find which has the larger impact, then talk to both requesters. Often one can move by a day. I would agree a plan, deliver the first, and keep the second person updated."

**Common mistakes:** Silently dropping one.

**Beginner adaptation:** Coursework clash.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Between managers.

## Q69. How do you make decisions?

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Decision-making process.

**Answer framework:** Gather facts, options, risks, decide, review.

**Example answer:** "I define the decision and the deadline, collect key facts, list options with pros and cons, and ask someone to challenge my choice. Then I decide and review the outcome."

**Common mistakes:** Always deferring to others.

**Beginner adaptation:** Choosing methods in a project.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** High-stakes example.

## Q70. How do you make sure your work is accurate?

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Quality control.

**Answer framework:** Checks, tools, second pair of eyes, learn from errors.

**Example answer:** "I use a checklist, compare totals with the source, and read the work after a break. For important reports I ask a colleague to review. I log errors to find patterns."

**Common mistakes:** Claiming you never make errors.

**Beginner adaptation:** Proofreading and checks in coursework.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Team review systems.

CHAPTER 18

# Strengths, weaknesses and motivation (Q71 to Q80)

## Q71. What is your greatest strength?

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Whether your strength matches the job and is real.

**Answer framework:** One strength, proof, relevance.

**Example answer:** "Organisation. When I ran our department's open day I built a one-page schedule, assigned each volunteer a zone and held a ten-minute briefing. Nothing was double booked, and the head of department asked me to plan next year's. For this role, that same planning would help with your event calendar."

**Common mistakes:** Listing adjectives with no proof.

**Beginner adaptation:** Back it with a course or volunteer example.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Choose the strength most tied to the role's top need.

## Q72. What is your greatest weakness?

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Honesty and self-improvement.

**Answer framework:** A real, non-critical weakness, what you do about it, progress.

**Example answer:** "I used to avoid delegating because I wanted things done my way. It left me overloaded. I now write a short brief for each task, hand it over and check at agreed points. Last quarter I delegated three reports and still met all deadlines."

**Common mistakes:** "I work too hard" or a weakness that disqualifies you.

**Beginner adaptation:** Public speaking or time management, with steps you take.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** A management or technical gap with a proven fix.

## Q73. What skill are you currently developing?

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Learning drive.

**Answer framework:** The skill, why, how, progress.

**Example answer:** "Spreadsheet automation. I spent too long on repeated tasks, so I am taking a free course on macros and have already automated our weekly report, which saves about an hour."

**Common mistakes:** Naming a skill irrelevant to the job.

**Beginner adaptation:** Skills linked to the target field.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Adjacent skills that broaden your scope.

## Q74. What kind of work gives you energy?

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Fit with the role.

**Answer framework:** Type of work, example, link.

**Example answer:** "Explaining things to people who are lost. When I tutored first-year students in chemistry, the moment someone said 'oh, I see' made my day. That is why a training role appeals to me."

**Common mistakes:** Naming work the job does not have.

**Beginner adaptation:** Use class or volunteer experiences.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Show a pattern across roles.

## Q75. What does success mean to you?

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Values and ambition.

**Answer framework:** Personal and professional definition with a recent example.

**Example answer:** "Leaving things better than I found them. After my last project I left a handover document, and the next team started in a day instead of a week. That counts as success to me, along with meeting targets."

**Common mistakes:** Only money or title.

**Beginner adaptation:** Growth, learning and contribution.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Impact, people and results.

## Q76. How do you maintain work-life balance?

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Sustainability and boundaries.

**Answer framework:** Habits, flexibility, example.

**Example answer:** "I plan my week on Sunday, protect two evenings, and stay flexible at deadlines. In busy seasons I work longer, then take time back afterwards."

**Common mistakes:** Saying you never need balance, or implying low commitment.

**Beginner adaptation:** Balance of study, work and rest.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Boundaries with teams and clients.

## Q77. How do you stay motivated with repetitive tasks?

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Reliability.

**Answer framework:** Purpose, small improvements, routine.

**Example answer:** "I remind myself who the task serves. In my data entry job I set mini-targets and looked for errors to prevent. I found a pattern that saved checking time."

**Common mistakes:** Saying you hate repetition.

**Beginner adaptation:** Entry-level repetitive tasks.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Automating or delegating.

## Q78. What are you most passionate about?

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Genuine interests and energy.

**Answer framework:** Passion, evidence, link to work.

**Example answer:** "Accessible design. I volunteered to test a charity's website with a screen reader and found six issues. They fixed them, and I enjoyed it so much I started studying accessibility standards."

**Common mistakes:** Passion with no evidence.

**Beginner adaptation:** Courses and volunteering.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Long-term pursuit with impact.

## Q79. What do you value in a workplace culture?

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Cultural fit.

**Answer framework:** Two values, example, how you contribute.

**Example answer:** "Open communication and learning from mistakes. At my last job we held a short review after each project, and I found it made us better. I would like to continue that."

**Common mistakes:** Naming values the employer clearly lacks.

**Beginner adaptation:** Student teams and part-time workplaces.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Compare with cultures you've worked in.

## Q80. What is a strength of yours that is not obvious on your resume?

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Hidden value.

**Answer framework:** Strength, evidence, relevance.

**Example answer:** "Calm in conflict. It's not a job title, but at the restaurant I often settled disputes between guests and staff. I listen, summarise, and offer options. It helps with client calls."

**Common mistakes:** Repeating a resume item.

**Beginner adaptation:** Life experience, caring roles.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Mentoring, cross-cultural skills, language.

CHAPTER 19

# Career and salary questions (Q81 to Q90)

## Q81. What salary are you expecting?

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Whether your expectations fit their budget.

**Answer framework:** Researched range, flexibility, ask theirs.

**Example answer:** "From my research on similar roles in this city, I'm looking at a range of 38,000 to 44,000, depending on the full package. I would like to understand the scope of the role better. What range have you budgeted?"

**Common mistakes:** Naming a number without research.

**Beginner adaptation:** Use public pay data for entry roles.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Anchor on recent comparable roles and your scope.

## Q82. What is your current salary?

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Your baseline or their anchor.

**Answer framework:** Rules differ by location. Redirect to the role's range, or answer truthfully if you choose.

**Example answer:** "I would prefer to focus on the value of this role. Based on market research, my target is about 52,000. If it helps, I can share my total package for context."

**Common mistakes:** Lying.

**Beginner adaptation:** Say you are seeking your first salary and ask the range.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Frame your total package and scope.

## Q83. When can you start?

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Availability.

**Answer framework:** Notice period or date, flexibility.

**Example answer:** "My contract requires one month's notice, so I could begin on the first of next month. I'm happy to discuss a handover plan."

**Common mistakes:** Promising a date you cannot meet.

**Beginner adaptation:** State your graduation or exam end date.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** State notice and handover.

## Q84. Do you have other offers or interviews?

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Competition and interest.

**Answer framework:** Be honest, show preference.

**Example answer:** "I'm in the process with two other companies, but this role is my first choice because of the team. I'd have a decision by the end of the month."

**Common mistakes:** Inventing offers.

**Beginner adaptation:** Say you're interviewing and prefer this role.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Share timelines carefully.

### Q85. Are you willing to relocate or travel?

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Flexibility.

**Answer framework:** Honest limits and conditions.

**Example answer:** "I can travel up to a quarter of the time. Relocation would depend on the package and timing, as my partner works locally. I am happy to discuss."

**Common mistakes:** Saying yes then refusing later.

**Beginner adaptation:** Show flexibility if true.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Discuss family and relocation support.

### Q86. How flexible are you on salary?

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Negotiation stance.

**Answer framework:** Priorities, total package.

**Example answer:** "There is some flexibility if the role offers growth and training. I'd look at the whole package, including development budget and review dates."

**Common mistakes:** Saying you will accept anything.

**Beginner adaptation:** Emphasise learning value, within fair pay.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Anchor on market and total rewards.

## Q87. Why is there a gap in your employment history?

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Explanation, not judgement.

**Answer framework:** Short fact, what you did, readiness.

**Example answer:** "I took eight months to care for a family member. During that time I completed a bookkeeping certificate. I'm now fully available and ready to return."

**Common mistakes:** Over-apologising or lying.

**Beginner adaptation:** Gap between school and work: mention study, projects.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Name the reason briefly, show currency.

## Q88. Why have you changed jobs frequently?

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Stability and pattern.

**Answer framework:** Reasons, growth, commitment now.

**Example answer:** "Two roles were fixed-term contracts and one company closed. Each gave me new skills, such as inventory systems. I'm looking for a longer-term place."

**Common mistakes:** Blaming employers.

**Beginner adaptation:** Internships and seasonal work explain short stints.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Show the career thread.

## Q89. Why are you changing careers?

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Commitment and transferable skills.

**Answer framework:** Reason, evidence of preparation, transferable skills.

**Example answer:** "After eight years teaching, I found I most enjoyed designing materials. I completed a certificate in instructional design and built three modules for a charity. My classroom experience helps me understand learners."

**Common mistakes:** Disparaging your old field.

**Beginner adaptation:** Explain interest shift from your degree.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Highlight transferable results.

## Q90. Would you accept a lower position or pay?

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Motivation and realism.

**Answer framework:** Honest conditions and long-term interest.

**Example answer:** "I'm open to it if there is a clear route to grow, as I'm changing fields. I'd want to discuss expectations and a review point."

**Common mistakes:** Agreeing and resenting later.

**Beginner adaptation:** Show willingness to start at the bottom.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Be clear on non-negotiables.

CHAPTER 20

# Challenging and unexpected questions (Q91 to Q100)

## Q91. If you were a kitchen tool, which would you be?

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Creativity and composure.

**Answer framework:** Pick quickly, give a work-related reason.

**Example answer:** "A sharp knife: precise and useful when carefully used. I like to cut a task into clear pieces. I also know a knife needs care, so I rest and sharpen my skills."

**Common mistakes:** Refusing or joking only.

**Beginner adaptation:** Keep it light and link to your study style.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Link to a leadership trait.

## Q92. Sell me this pen.

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Sales approach and listening.

**Answer framework:** Ask needs first, match feature to need, close.

**Example answer:** "Before I describe it, can I ask what you usually write with, and what you dislike about it? If you sign contracts often, this pen's smooth ink would help. Would you like to try it?"

**Common mistakes:** Listing features without questions.

**Beginner adaptation:** Practise asking questions.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Show consultative selling.

## Q93. Tell me something that is not on your resume.

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Personality and depth.

**Answer framework:** A real fact with relevance.

**Example answer:** "I taught myself basic Spanish in a year using audio lessons and a conversation partner. It shows I stick with long goals."

**Common mistakes:** Over-sharing private details.

**Beginner adaptation:** Interests that show discipline.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Unusual projects.

## Q94. What would you do if you won the lottery?

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Values and commitment.

**Answer framework:** Honest, relevant, show you enjoy work.

**Example answer:** "I'd help my family and travel, but I'd likely still work in education because I enjoy it. I might choose projects with more freedom."

**Common mistakes:** Saying you'd quit tomorrow.

**Beginner adaptation:** Show purpose.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Show sustainable commitment.

## Q95. What is your biggest regret?

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Reflection.

**Answer framework:** Real regret, lesson, action.

**Example answer:** "I did not ask for a mentor early. I struggled alone for a year. Now I seek mentors and have two."

**Common mistakes:** Saying none.

**Beginner adaptation:** A study choice you adjusted.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** A career lesson.

## Q96. You don't meet one of our requirements. How will you cover that gap?

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Honesty and learning plan.

**Answer framework:** Acknowledge, show related experience, plan.

**Example answer:** "That's right, I haven't used your CRM, though I've used two similar tools. I'd complete your training in the first week and ask a colleague to review my first entries."

**Common mistakes:** Denying the gap.

**Beginner adaptation:** Point to fast learning.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Show prior ramp-up speed.

## Q97. You see a colleague cutting corners. What do you do?

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Integrity and judgement.

**Answer framework:** Check facts, speak to them, escalate if serious.

**Example answer:** "I would first check I understood. If it's a safety or compliance issue, I'd speak to them privately, and if it continued, report it to my supervisor."

**Common mistakes:** Ignoring it.

**Beginner adaptation:** Show willingness to ask.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Cite policy and reporting channels.

## Q98. Have you ever been fired or asked to leave?

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Honesty and growth.

**Answer framework:** Truth, ownership, lesson.

**Example answer:** "Yes, from a sales job in 2019. I missed targets and had not asked for help. I took a role in customer service, learned the product, and have met my targets since."

**Common mistakes:** Lying or blaming.

**Beginner adaptation:** If never, say so; if from a part-time job, be brief.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Frame calmly with facts.

## Q99. Is there anything we have not asked that you would like us to know?

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Your closing priorities.

**Answer framework:** Summarise fit, add one missed point.

**Example answer:** "We haven't discussed my customer survey work. It gave me experience in analysing feedback, which fits your role. Overall, I think my background matches your needs."

**Common mistakes:** "No" or a rambling closing.

**Beginner adaptation:** One missed project.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Summarise best fit.

## Q100. What concerns might we have about hiring you?

**What the interviewer wants to understand:** Self-awareness and confidence.

**Answer framework:** Name the likely concern, give evidence against it.

**Example answer:** "You may worry that I'm new to the industry. I've shadowed an analyst for two weeks and built a sample report. I learn quickly and ask good questions."

**Common mistakes:** Getting defensive.

**Beginner adaptation:** Address lack of experience.

**Experienced candidate adaptation:** Address overqualification or salary.

# Appendix A. Story bank: 30 prompts

These are prompts to help you find real stories, not answers. Write one or two lines of true facts for each. Leave blank any that do not apply.

1. A time you finished something difficult.
2. A time you were wrong.
3. A group project that went well.
4. A group project that went badly.
5. A deadline you nearly missed.
6. Something you taught yourself.
7. A time you helped someone learn.
8. A time you spotted an error.
9. A time you disagreed with someone.
10. A complaint you handled.
11. A time you were new and unsure.
12. A role you took without being asked.
13. A time you led, formally or informally.
14. A time you followed someone else's lead well.
15. A time you worked with limited money or time.
16. A time you changed your plan.
17. A time you received hard feedback.
18. A time you gave hard feedback.
19. A task you improved.
20. A time you stayed calm.
21. A time you were under pressure from others.
22. A time you refused a request.

23. A time you asked for help.
24. A time you made a decision with missing facts.
25. A time you worked with someone very different from you.
26. A time you represented a group.
27. A time you explained something technical.
28. A time you did something you were not trained for.
29. A time you kept going when you were bored.
30. A time you are proud of that nobody noticed.

For each story you keep, fill in the STAR worksheet in Chapter 7.

# Appendix B. Common mistakes

| Mistake | Fix |
|---|---|
| Memorising sample answers | Memorise facts and structure, not sentences |
| Inventing stories | Use true ones; ask to move on if you have none |
| Talking too long | Aim for 60 to 120 seconds |
| Saying "we" only | Say what you did |
| Criticising past employers | State facts, focus on what you learned |
| Not researching the employer | Spend 45 minutes on the website and news |
| No questions at the end | Prepare at least four |
| Asking pay first | Wait until the offer or the employer raises it |
| Sending one resume everywhere | Tailor the top third |
| Not following up | Thank-you within 24 hours |
| Negotiating with false claims | Never claim offers you do not have |
| Ignoring tests of the video link | Test the day before |

# Appendix C. Glossary

**ATS (applicant tracking system):** Software employers use to receive and manage applications.

**Behavioural question:** A question about something you actually did.

**CAR:** Challenge, Action, Result.

**Case interview:** A scenario you analyse aloud.

**Cover letter:** A short letter explaining why you fit a role.

**Hiring manager:** The person who will manage the new hire.

**Offer:** A formal proposal of employment with terms.

**Panel interview:** An interview with several interviewers at once.

**Parsing:** Software extracting fields from a document.

**Situational question:** A hypothetical "what would you do".

**STAR:** Situation, Task, Action, Result.

**Structured interview:** The same questions and scoring for every candidate.

**Transferable skills:** Skills useful across roles or fields.

# Conclusion

You now have a method rather than a script. This week, do five things: write your master resume using the structure in Chapter 2; update LinkedIn using Chapter 4; fill in at least eight prompts from Appendix A; pick ten questions from Chapters 14 to 20 and answer them aloud from your real stories; and set up the tracker and week one of the 30 day planner in Chapter 13.

No book can promise an offer. What you can control is how clearly and truthfully you present real work. Do that consistently, learn from each interview, and adjust.

# Appendix D. References and further reading

All accessed 2026-11-07.


- LinkedIn Help, "Create a good LinkedIn profile": https://www.linkedin.com/help/linkedin/answer/a554351 (profile elements and the "up to 2X more profile views" statement in Chapter 4).
- Roche Careers, "Resume Parsing FAQ": https://careers.roche.com/global/en/resume-parsing-faq (an employer's view of parsing and formatting, Chapter 3).
- Ohio State University Engineering Career Services, "FAQs about applicant tracking software": https://ecs.osu.edu/news/2020/08/faqs-about-applicant-tracking-software (recruiters' role, honest tailoring, Chapters 2 and 3).
- US Office of Personnel Management, "Structured Interviews": https://www.opm.gov/policy-data-oversight/assessment-and-selection/structured-interviews/ (past behaviour and hypothetical questions, Chapters 1, 7, 9).
- US Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook: https://www.bls.gov/ooh/ (US pay data by occupation, Chapter 11).


Competitor listings on Gumroad were reviewed for positioning only; their page text could not be read, so no claims are drawn from them.